

Episode 117: It's March Already But... New Year Special Edition – *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM* Notes (Final Part 3) "SW" Main Feature Complete Scene Colour Design Notes! Part 2

Yesterday marked exactly one year since I became freelance. Wow, that was fast (laugh). Still, it was quite a thrilling year. While I'd secretly (!) worked on various projects before, this was definitely a big difference.

One year ago today was also the day I said farewell to my other secret name "Kunioto Kunio" (國音邦生) when I went freelance. For me, this name was both a brand and an emotional anchor. It was a day of resolve, saying goodbye to that name.

One way or another, it was quite an emotionally intense year.

Even so, being able to continue receiving work without interruption like this is truly something to be grateful for—I'm endlessly thankful.

Now then.

Continuing "*STRONG WORLD* Main Feature Complete Scene Colour Design Notes!" for this major theatrical work that was my first big job after going freelance.

Scene 34: Supplement

There's work called "Special Effects," mainly adding brush textures to characters and props, blending wind and smoke with backgrounds and cel-drawn parts—well, it's like a magician profession that does various things, and for this work we asked Ota Nao-kun. I've been working with him continuously since *Magical DoReMi Movie: Secret of the Frog Stone*.

In traditional Toei work style, Special Effects teams would handle brush work like smoke with "Here goes!" but this time we asked photography to handle all work they could, and had them focus on areas where handiwork could really show its power.

Particularly in Scene 34, we asked for texture processing on the Tone Dial. When I requested "When Nami finishes recording her message and places it on the ground, make it shine as if there are emotions there," it was crafted with atmosphere as if precious life dwelt there. Much gratitude!

Scene 35: Palace Command Room

Like the first half, character brightness is somewhat suppressed to match the dimness.

Scenes 36–38: Outside Palace, Various

From around here time becomes night. From then on, it's endless night scenes until the battle ends.

For monsters responding to Captain Scarlett's roar and enhanced soldiers, I deliberately made night scene colours bright. Thinking realistically, you'd darken them more to match background colours for atmosphere, but doing that raises the screen's age appeal. What we aimed for was screens for boys and girls, "manga movie" screens, so we thought about showing characters and monsters as clearly as possible.

However, cuts where story development called for "this cut should be really dark!" were properly crafted.

The Daft Green felling scene (Scene 38) was actually a scene where both animation and backgrounds finally came up when the production schedule was quite pressed. I think the white trunk feeling of Daft Green was a bit insufficient.

Scenes 25–26, 30: Pirates Gathered at Port to Palace Command Room

Matching pirate captain colours and command room pirates and navigators—this area was all Kobiki-san work.

Inside the command room, character brightness was suppressed to match background brightness. Even in dim places, it's brightness that looks natural through balance.

Den Den Mushi wandering the village, plus those appearing in island ship bridge and command room—also Kobiki-san work. When I make them they tend toward realistic, so I aimed for a manga-like feel. The unbalanced feeling creates good atmosphere.

Scene 40, 42: Palace Command Room

Nami's formal wear debut scene. ...Rather, for us the key was the "kotatsu" (laugh). I asked Kobiki-san to handle this too, but we had the discussion "What's piled on top of the kotatsu?" "Fruit? But this looks like big carrots, right? (sweat)" "If what they're eating is oranges, I'll forgive the rest (laugh)," I said. But this too became quite convincing with Special Effects magic (laugh).

Scene 41: Xiao's Village Fire

This scene also matched colours created in advance for the trailer—Kobiki work. This scene also took work until quite late, didn't it?

Scene 43: Xiao's Village Burned Ruins

Franky and others arrive at the burned ruins. The scene where the Straw Hat crew assembles.

Initially, the art board for this scene that came up had the same series of night colours as other night scenes around the palace. But I thought this should be a bit different. The dejected feeling of being thoroughly beaten by Shiki, plus losing Nami—that despair. And the scene where spirits rise toward "raid" after hearing Nami's message. So I proposed "How about somewhat cold, strongly blue moonlight?" and they modified it in that direction.

Transparent night colours that make characters feel moonlight. It finished with good balance.

However, one failure in this scene: the smoke wafting around. I tried creating various detailed colours to match backgrounds for depth perception. But the colours I made apparently had too low saturation, and when photography applied blur processing, oh my, the smoke lost too much colour and became mere grey. Grey on the blue-finished background felt somewhat reddish. Hmm. I was aiming for somewhat harder colours, so disappointing.

Ah, this type of adjustment needs close collaboration with photography doing actual compositing—a lesson scene. But even subtracting that, the scene finished with good feeling.

Scene 44: Palace Island

The scene where island ships carrying pirate captains arrive at palace island's sea. 3DCG island ships landing in equally CG seas, but waves kicked up by island ships are 2D animation—a hybrid. Probably making everything CG would be easier, but that would feel different. It would surely have become a "different thing" feeling. Having animated waves there creates balance with other scenes.

Scene 45: Palace Command Room

Which gesture represented which content, I wonder? (laugh)

Scene 46: Outside Palace, Daft Green Plantings

And what Indigo conveyed was that they'd captured Nami (laugh).

For outdoor night scenes around the palace, in my initial design plan I intended to create about four subtly different "night colours." One for moonlit night colours when Sunny crashes in, one for night colours near palace building lights, one for night colours on palace rooftops, and night colours around this Daft Green area.

But ultimately, I made them all the same "night colour." There are various reasons, but one was snow. Snow constantly danced on screen, and later became blizzards. In that case, doing subtle things wouldn't be very effective. Rather, organising everything the same would reduce work hassles and let us properly spend effort where we wanted to add touches—that was also a consideration.

Considering balance with work volume while properly establishing screens under time pressure—I consider that part of my job too.

Oh, the scene where Nami gets caught by iron spears—I secretly remembered Anthy from "Utena" just a bit (laugh).

Scene 47– Palace Interior Assembly Hall

Anyway, a spaciouly broad, gorgeous, bright great hall. Pirate captains lined up there. And a Kobiki-san work scene (laugh). Reference copies were distributed for animation matching, but many cuts inevitably didn't come up as intended, so detailed corrections beyond just colours were done bit by bit on cel data.

Scene 52: Caldera Lakeside Sunny

This time, Sunny was made with 3DCG in principle. And 3D scene colours are naturally my job too. For this Sunny too, I provided colour samples matched to backgrounds scene by scene, and they worked based on those.

They'd output single images from models assembled for specific scenes and cuts, then I'd layer colour corrections using adjustment layers. Plus detailed nuances were conveyed verbally to staff like "more like this feeling" (laugh).

Scene 54: Palace Front Garden

The scene where Sunny crashes in with full moon backdrop. Also a 2D/3D hybrid. This was a scene where I thought about making overall contrast stronger but stopped. Instead, I could properly craft impressions in key cuts.

Scene 60– Assembly Hall Raid

In the earlier teaser, there was a cut with Luffy and others lined up in formal wear against backlight—that visual was so cool that we absolutely had to do it in the main feature too!

So for the raid scene, darkening just before Luffy's group bursts through the sliding doors was to recreate that cut. Around here, it wasn't about physical logic but atmosphere and impression priority!

Smoke from Luffy's group's firearms. The blast smoke from firing barrels is black powder-type black smoke, but the first shot is darkest, then gradually becomes greyer. Landing smoke is also black-type initially, but smoke rising from floors in subsequent cuts gradually becomes lighter grey as cuts progress.

The reason is both Luffy's group and pirates wear "black." If smoke is also black, screens become busy and important character acting becomes hard to understand.

Scene 61– Around Palace Various

From here it's pure volume! Basically, inside the great hall is "normal," elsewhere like corridors have brightness adjusted to backgrounds. Once on rooftops, night colours. From Scene 65, monsters storm into the palace, but those follow the same basics.

Really, around here it's pure volume (laugh).

Scene 67: Outside Palace

While consulting about rescuing Nami and getting medicine, Shiki attacks. Here's the big technique "Lion's Threat Earth Roll" snow version. This time not CG but animation. Then Luffy appears. Gear Second mode.

Actually, I didn't understand what Gear Second or Third meant. So I asked the assistant director. They said "Power stored in his body emits light from inside, pink." "I see," I said. So I conceived that processing.

The body glowing itself—if you use high-contrast processing it looks bright. For that light being pink, make the steam clinging around his body pink reflection. If you also unify the body's shadow areas in high-saturation pink tones, overall it should look like pink glowing? And then photography skillfully put it together.

This was actually an application of *Dragon Ball's* Super Saiyan and Kamehameha wave. Techniques I'd used myself over ten years ago proved useful here (laugh).

...And writing this far, ah, time's up!

Ah, sorry, continuing one more time.

What will become of Nami afflicted by Daft!?

How will the Shiki VS Luffy battle go!?

With sweaty palms, please look forward to it!

(10.03.12)